

"I know there is one kind of cinema that exists in the world, that is good or bad cinema."

DYNASTY'S CHILD

From the Nehruvian socialism of a newly independent India in his early films to the cinematic rendering of a mature love story that didn't shy away from articulating passion, he set the template for many who came after him

■ By Madhu Jain

Raj Kapoor just won't die. The latest to grab a chunk of the legacy of the blue-eyed actor-director is Sanjay Leela Bhansali. His *Saawariya* is an ode to Kapoor—from the inception of the film to the recurring images and allusions to the cinema of Kapoor. Bhansali took off from the 1959 film *Anari*, in which Kapoor plays a rather naïve painter who comes to the city and lodges with a generous Christian landlady. Bhansali replaces the paintbrush with a guitar: he makes his protagonist, Kapoor scion Ranbir Kapoor, a musician.

The tantalising, infamous towel scene with the now-you-see-it-now-you-don't (Ranbir's) butt that made cinematic history is an ode to *Bobby*—to the scene in which Aruna Irani walks into young Rishi Kapoor's room. He comes out of the bathroom and drops his towel in surprise. Raj Kapoor's camera in the more restrained 1970s turned away at that point, keeping it all above the belt.

Kapoor's acting skills were formidable, equally convincing in his Charlie Chaplin-esque "little man" roles in films like *Shree 420* and *Teesri Kasam* or his portrayals of a man propelled by searing intensity (*Aag* and *Awara*). Yet, it is his directorial avatar that continues to inhabit the imagination of and inspire successive generations of film directors.

Kapoor set the template for many who came after him—from the Nehruvian socialism of a newly independent India in the R.K. banner's

early films predominantly characterised by smaller-than-life heroes and mostly written by K.A. Abbas (*Awara*, *Shree 420* and *Jaagte Raho*) to his fresh treatment of adolescent, star-crossed love in *Bobby* and the cinematic rendering of a mature love story that didn't shy away from articulating passion and lust in films like *Barsaat* and *Sangam*.

Kapoor was, arguably, the first to have his hero slap his heroine. The slap across Nargis's face in *Awara* still

resounds: it had shocked the audience. Kapoor was also the first Indian director to shoot abroad.

Perhaps it was the original showman's portrayal of Bombay in his films that continues to endear Kapoor to cineastes—particularly in *Shree 420*. Kapoor's storyboard was usually his own life, with him as the protagonist of most of his films. But after the box office failure of *Mera Naam Joker*, he handed over the R.K. banner's mantle of hero to his son Rishi Kapoor, who became his alter ego on the screen. "In *Bobby*, it was him, I was the body in which he put all kinds of colours," Rishi Kapoor told me.

The stories about Kapoor's popularity in the USSR and the Middle East are legendary: apparently Joseph Stalin asked Jawaharlal Nehru who this Kapoor, he was hearing so much about, was. Less known is the extent to which his films were loved in China. Vikram Seth recounts from his travels as a student through China in the early 1980s that some students cried upon meeting him, as they were mourning the death of "Lita"—Rita, the name of Nargis's character in *Awara*—and the actor had recently passed away.

Remember the cigarette holder that Nadira so eloquently put between her teeth in *Shree 420*? Nadira told me the prime minister of Israel at the time wanted it. As always, Raj Kapoor obliged.

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Q: How many musical instruments could Raj Kapoor play?

A: Five—harmonium, piano, accordion, tabla, and bulbul tarang.

Q: Which film marked his directorial debut?

A: *Aag*, he acted in it and produced it too.

Q: What quirk did he have about his movie titles?

A: Got them re-registered every 10 years.

Q: Which movie did he act in when he was 11?

A: *Inquilab* in 1935.

Q: What was the turning point of his career?

A: When director Kedar Sharma slapped him, making him serious about his work.